

# Pelvic-Floor Exercises & Bladder Training

Patient Information · Simple, proven first steps for leaks and urgency

WARWIKI

Two of the best first steps for bladder control need no medicine or surgery. **Pelvic floor exercises** (often called Kegels) strengthen the muscles that hold urine in. **Bladder training** teaches your bladder to wait longer between trips. They are safe, and they work best when you do them every day.

## How They Help

- **Pelvic floor exercises** build the support under the bladder and urethra. You leak less when you cough, lift or exercise. A quick squeeze can also calm a sudden urge.
- **Bladder training** slowly stretches the time between bathroom trips. It helps urgency, frequent trips and urge leaks.
- **After prostate removal for cancer**, starting exercises right away may help control come back sooner.

## Finding the Right Muscles

These are the muscles you would use to **stop the flow of urine** or hold back gas. Squeeze and lift them. Do **not** tighten your belly, buttocks or thighs, and do not hold your breath. Do not practice by stopping your stream; that is only a way to find the muscles.

If you cannot find them, a **pelvic floor physical therapist** can teach you, sometimes with a screen that shows the muscle working (biofeedback).

## Check Your Squeeze

Written or spoken instructions alone are often not enough. In one study, only about **half of women** squeezed the right way after brief instructions, and some pushed down instead. Pushing down can make leaks worse. Two simple checks:

- **If you have a vagina:** lying down, put one clean finger just inside. A correct squeeze feels like a gentle **squeeze and lift** around your finger.
- **If you have a penis:** a correct squeeze draws the **base of the penis in** and **lifts the scrotum** a little.

If you feel a push down or a bulge, stop. Ask your team to check your squeeze during an exam.

## Learn the Terms

### Pelvic floor

The sling of muscles that supports the bladder, bowel and, in women, the uterus.

### Kegels

Squeeze-and-lift exercises for the pelvic floor muscles.

### Bladder training

Slowly lengthening the time between bathroom trips.

### Bladder diary

A record of when you drink, urinate and leak.

### Urge suppression

Calming a sudden urge so you can reach the toilet without leaking.

### Biofeedback

A tool that shows when you are using the right muscles.

### Pelvic floor therapist

A physical therapist who treats these muscles.

**How long until it works?** Give pelvic floor exercises **at least 3 months** and bladder training **at least 6 weeks**. Like any exercise, the benefit fades if you stop, so make it a daily habit.

## A Simple Daily Routine

- 1 **Squeeze** the pelvic floor and hold. Start with what you can manage and hold a little longer as you get stronger. Then relax fully.
- 2 Do **at least 8 squeezes, 3 times a day**. Your therapist may change this for you.
- 3 Give a **quick, strong squeeze** right before you cough, sneeze or lift.
- 4 Relaxing fully between squeezes matters as much as the squeeze.

## Bladder Training

- Keep a **bladder diary** for 3 days to see your pattern.
- When an urge hits, **stop and stand or sit still**. Relax your belly, buttocks and jaw. Do a few quick squeezes and breathe slowly, or count backward to take your mind off it. When the urge fades, walk calmly to the toilet.
- Every few days, add about **15 minutes** between trips. Your team will help you set a comfortable goal.

## Good to Know

- You can do these **anywhere**, and no one can tell.
- Tie them to daily cues, such as meals or red lights.
- If you have **pelvic pain** or a very tight pelvic floor, the goal may be to **relax**, not strengthen. Ask your team.

### Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- Pain or pressure that gets worse with the exercises
- No change after about 3 months
- Burning when you urinate, blood in your urine, or a temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher

### Go to an emergency department if:

- You cannot urinate for several hours and your bladder feels full or painful
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

## Three Things to Remember

1. Squeeze the right muscles without holding your breath, and relax fully in between.
2. Stop and squeeze when an urge hits, then walk calmly.
3. Keep going for months. A therapist can help.